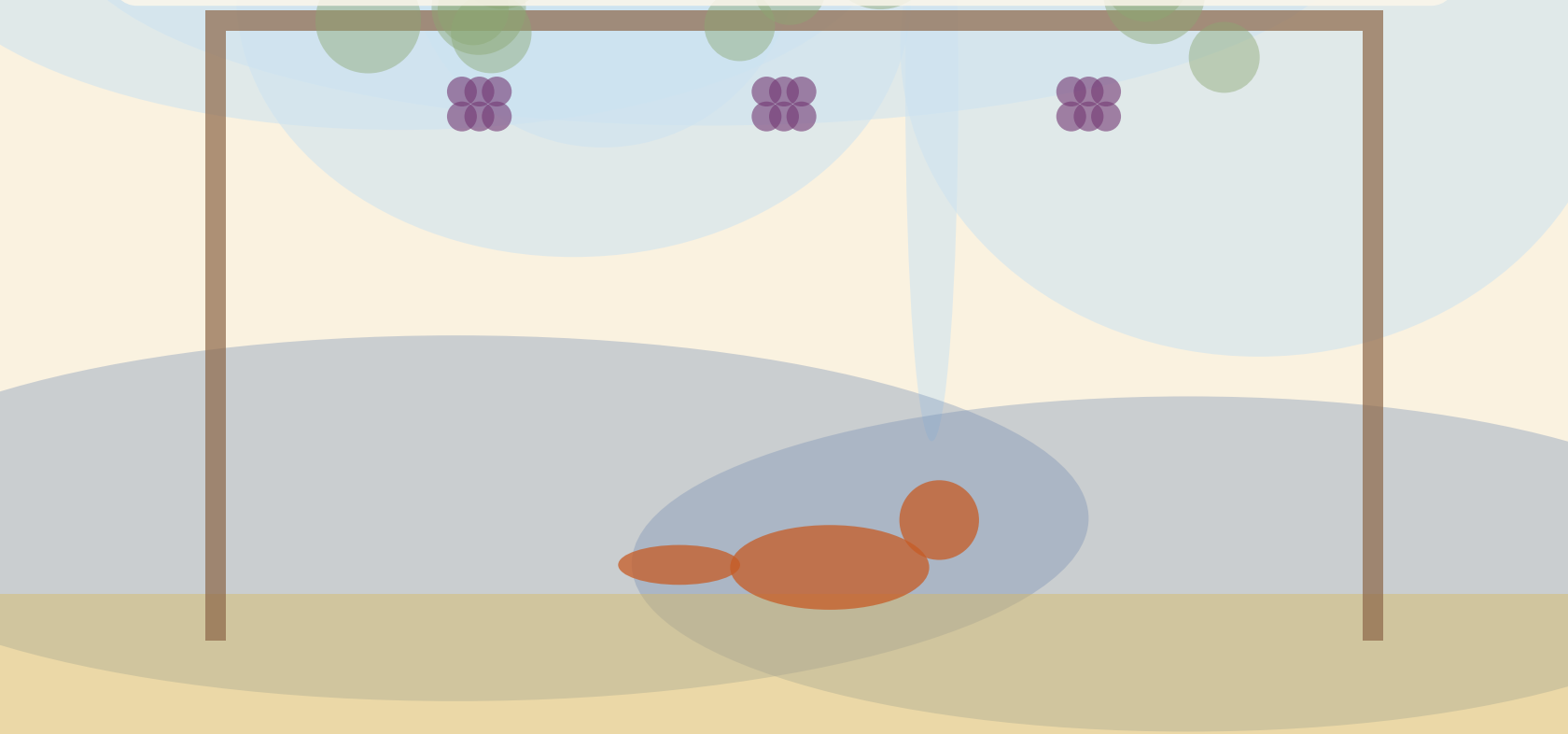
ART SLOT art/title.png (PLACEHOLDER)

for Immy

Fern and the High Grapes

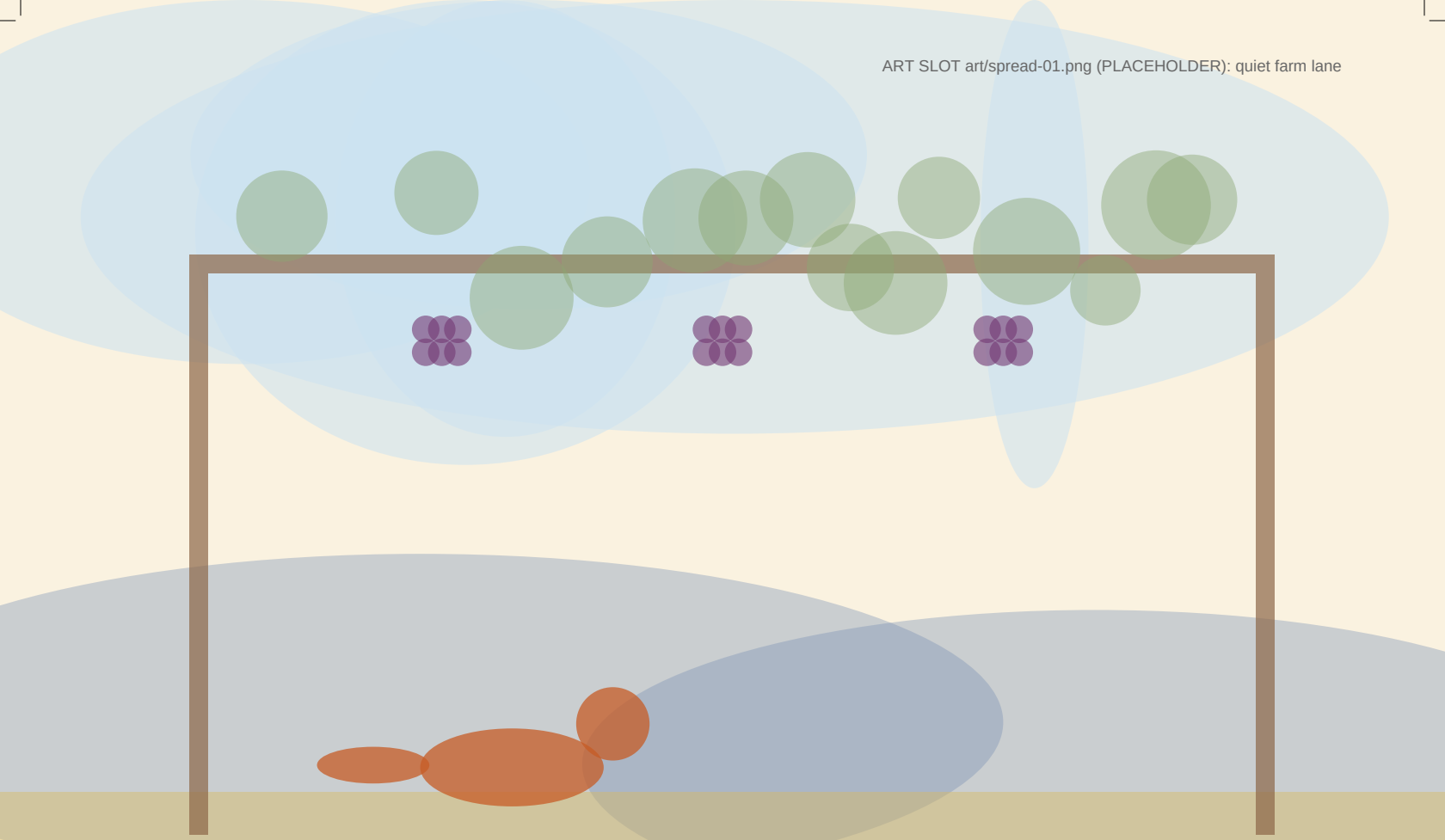


A new retelling of The Fox and the Grapes by Martin Schoffstall. Illustrated by [illustrator credit pending].

for Immy. Text copyright © 2026 Martin Schoffstall. All rights reserved. Illustrations: [illustrator credit pending].
Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (public domain).

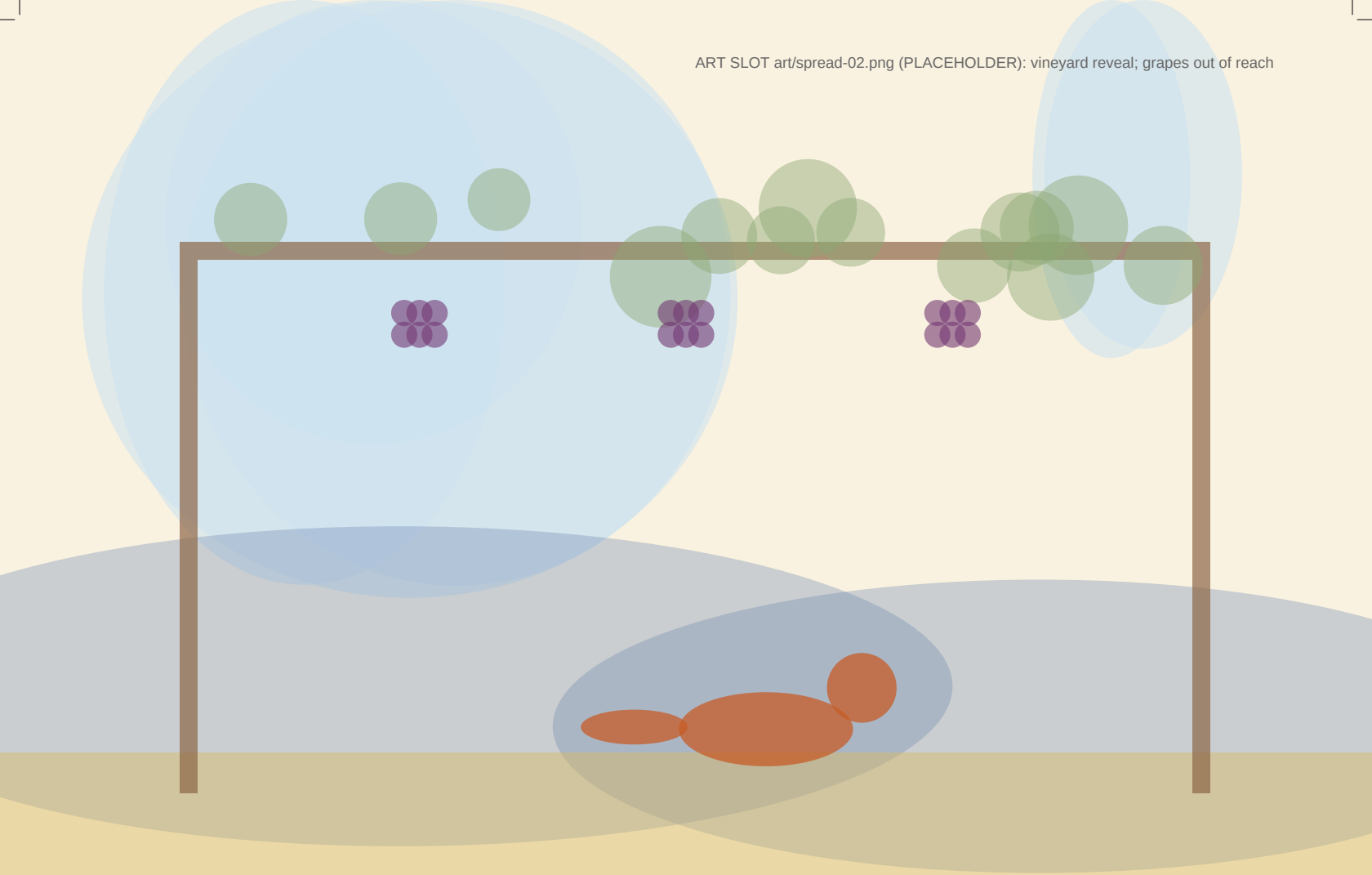


ART SLOT art/spread-01.png (PLACEHOLDER): quiet farm lane



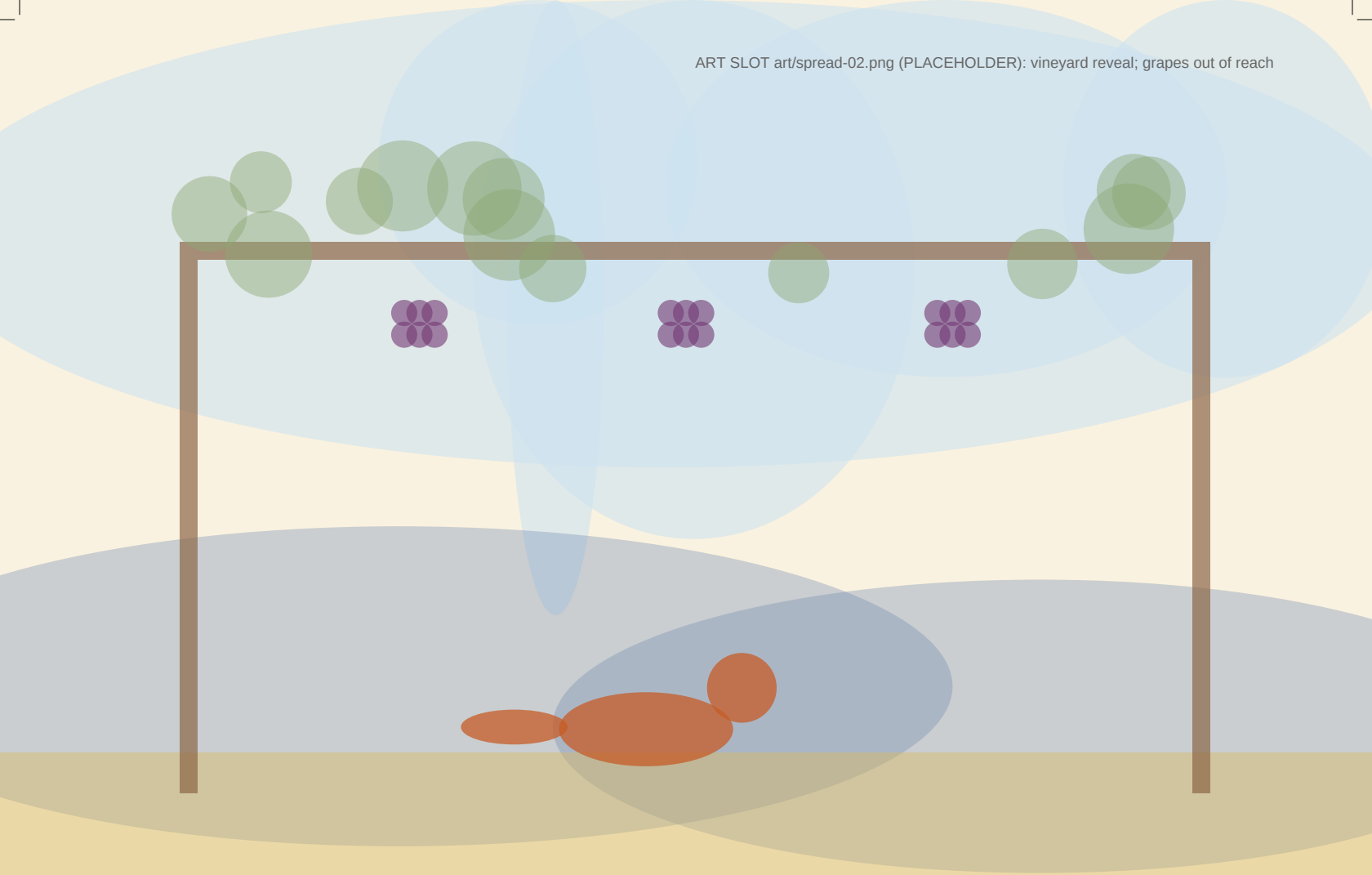
A new retelling of The Fox and the Grapes

ART SLOT art/spread-02.png (PLACEHOLDER): vineyard reveal; grapes out of reach



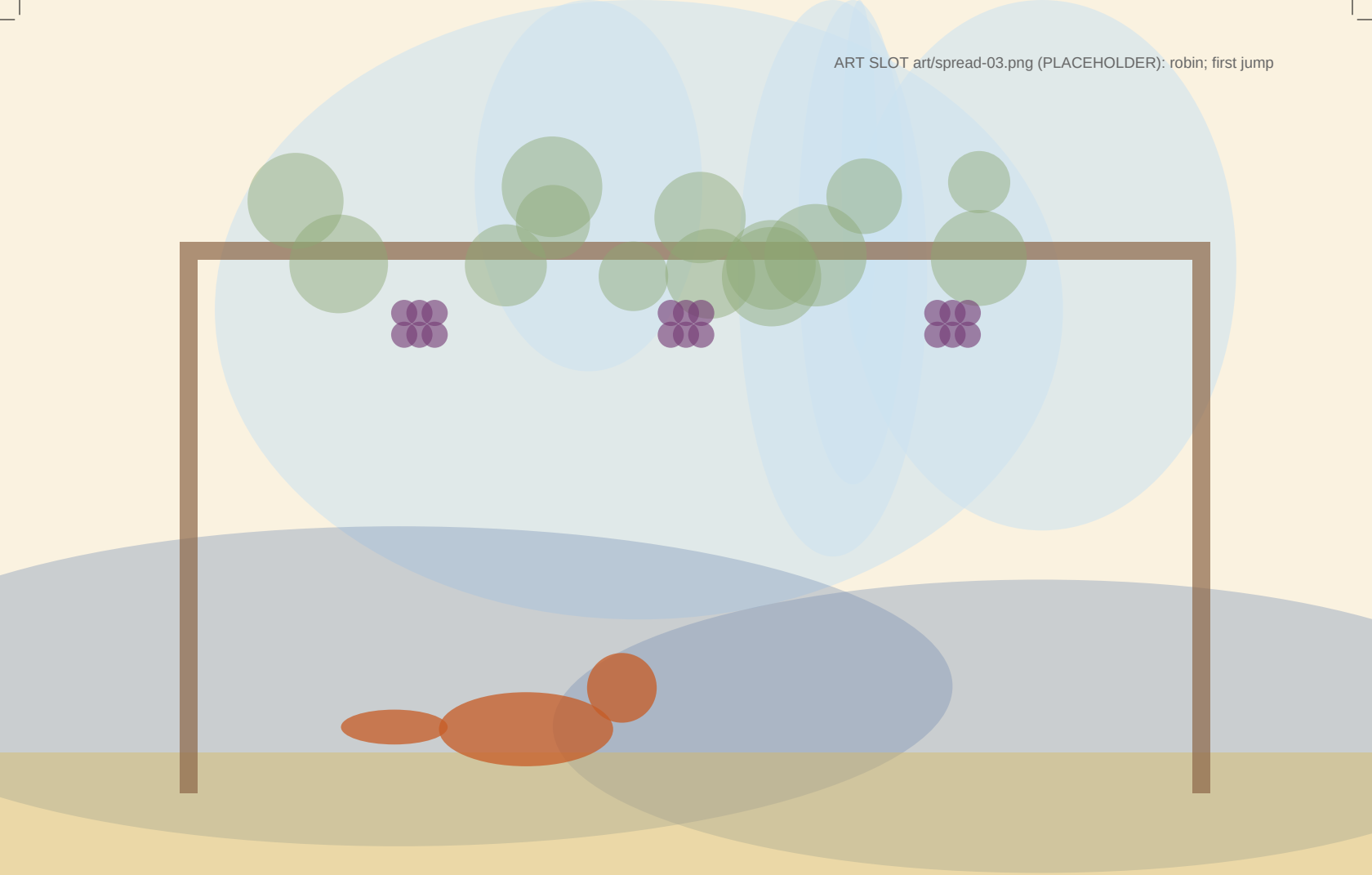
Along a farm lane, Fern the fox sniffed the warm summer air.

ART SLOT art/spread-02.png (PLACEHOLDER): vineyard reveal; grapes out of reach



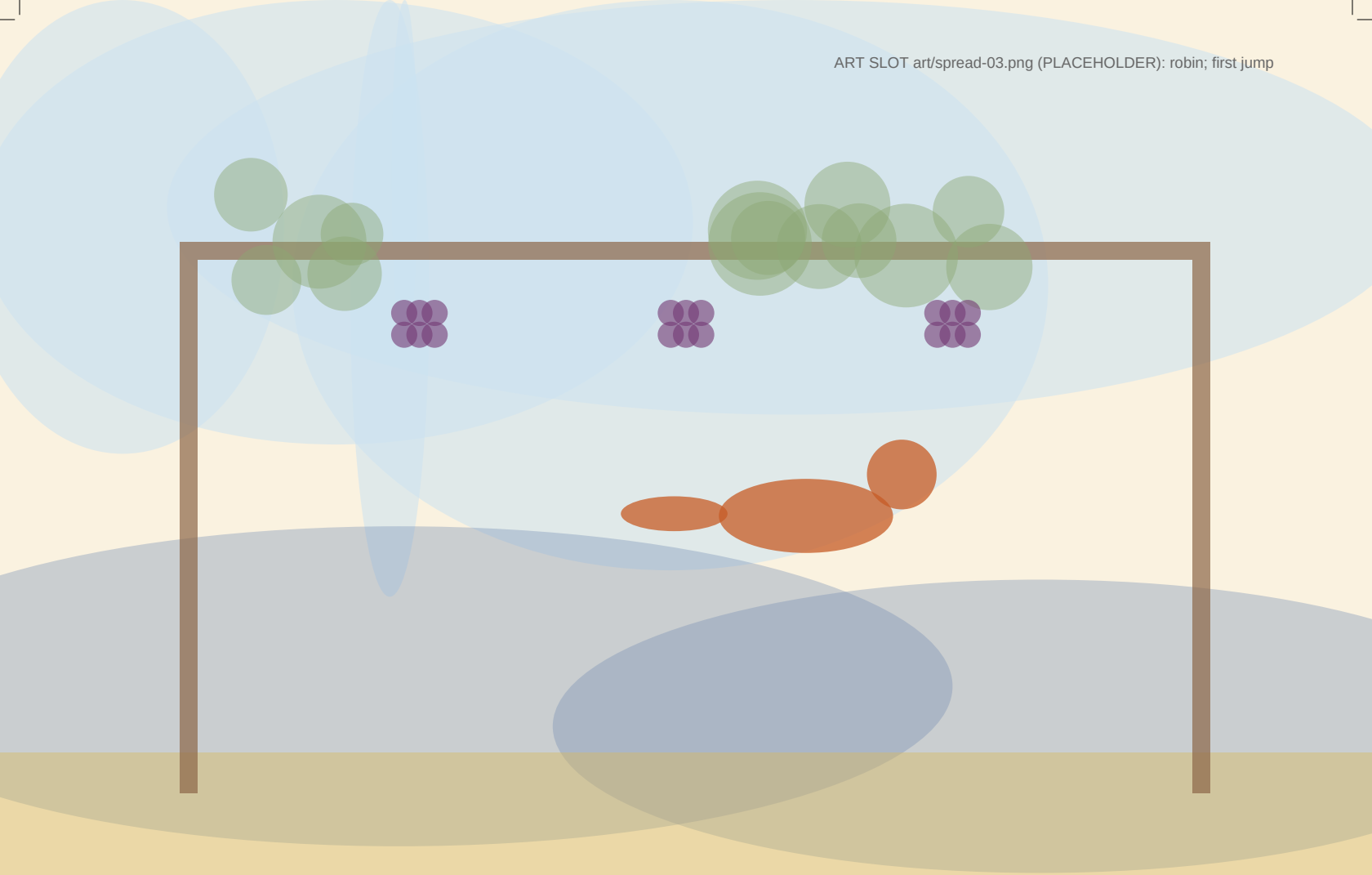
Sweet grapes hung from a vine overhead. Fern’s tummy rumbled.

ART SLOT art/spread-03.png (PLACEHOLDER): robin; first jump



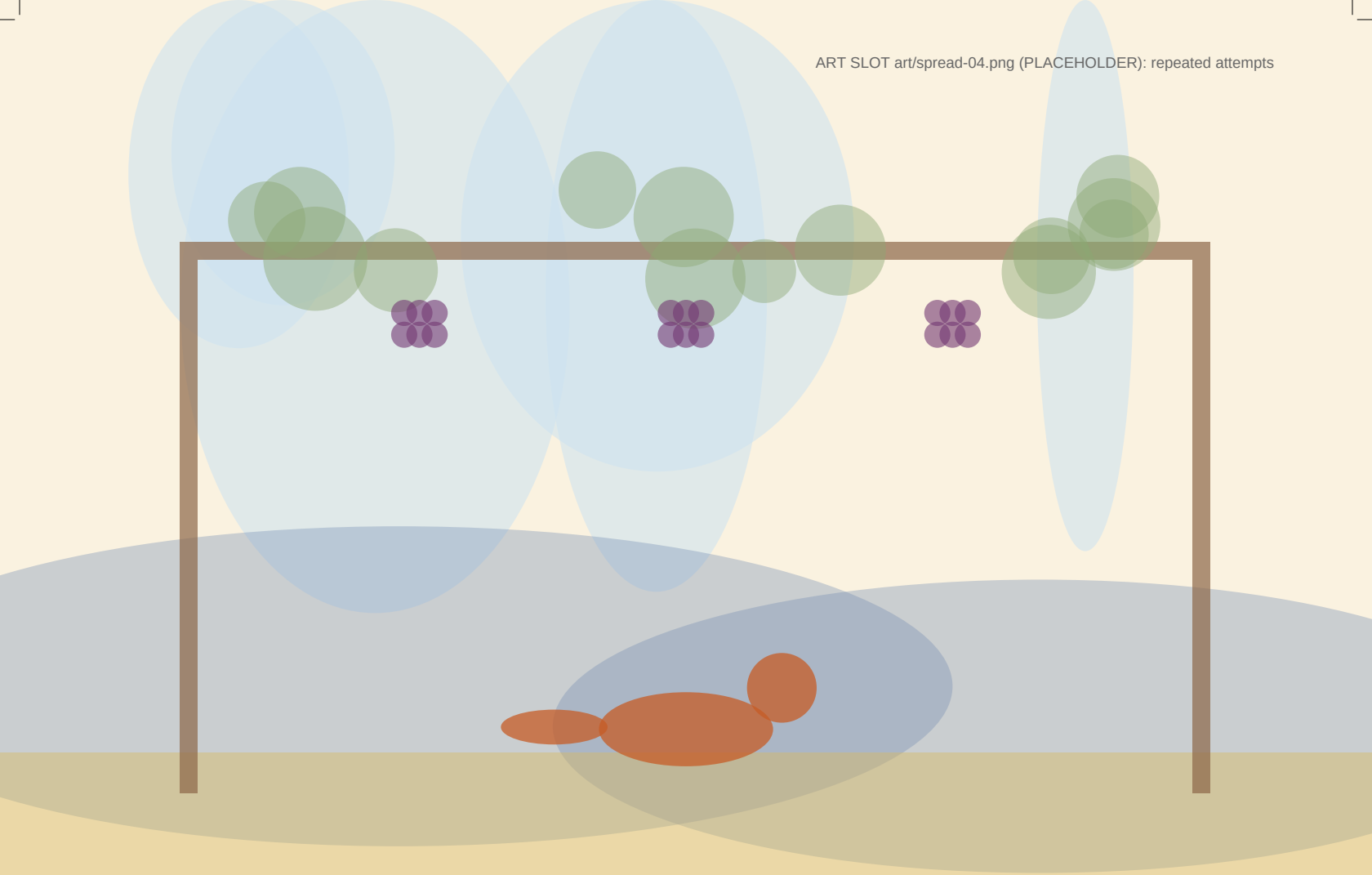
A robin perched beside a bunch. Fern wished she could reach it, too.

ART SLOT art/spread-03.png (PLACEHOLDER): robin; first jump



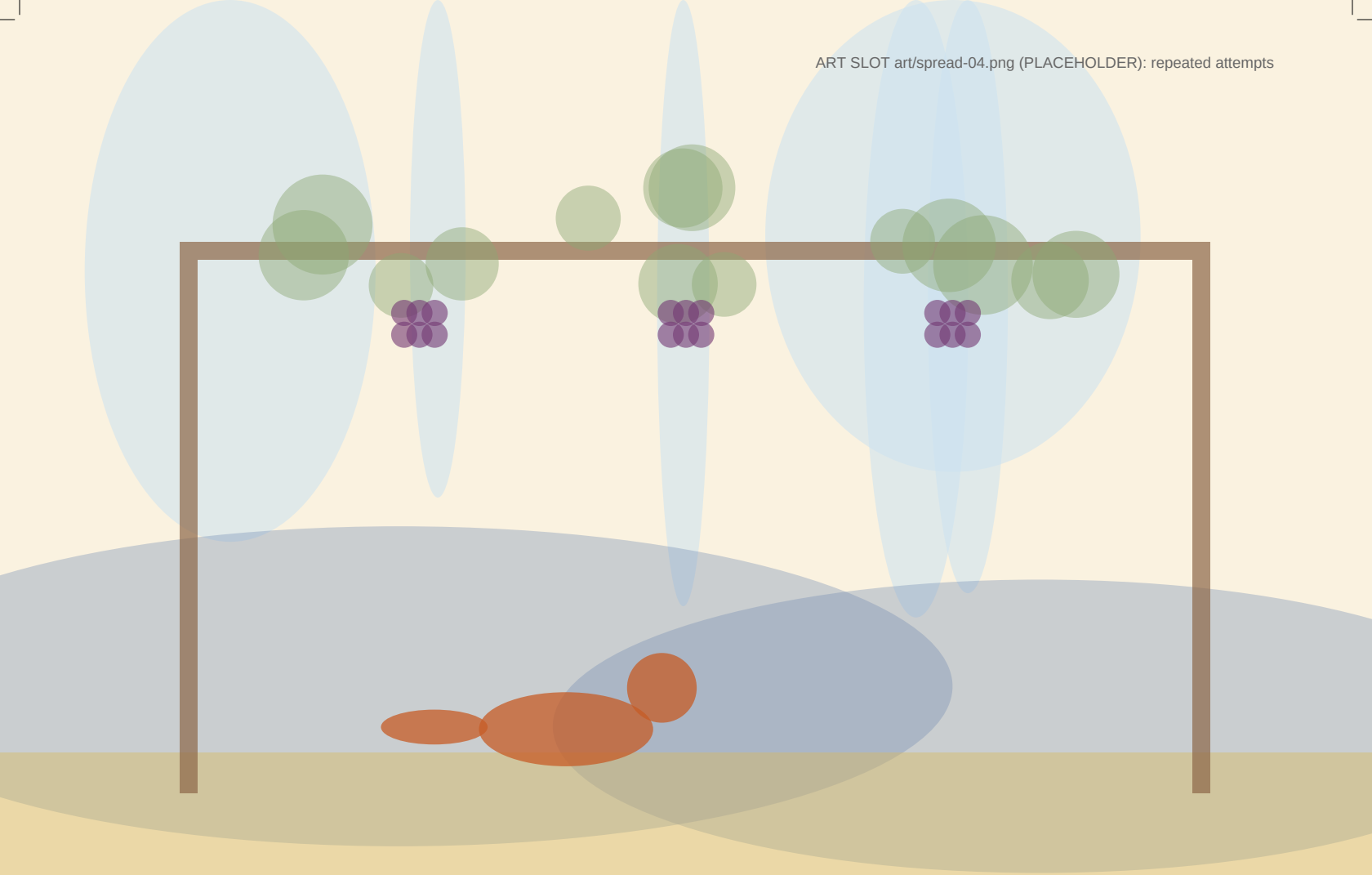
She crouched low, swished her tail, and sprang. Almost!

ART SLOT art/spread-04.png (PLACEHOLDER): repeated attempts



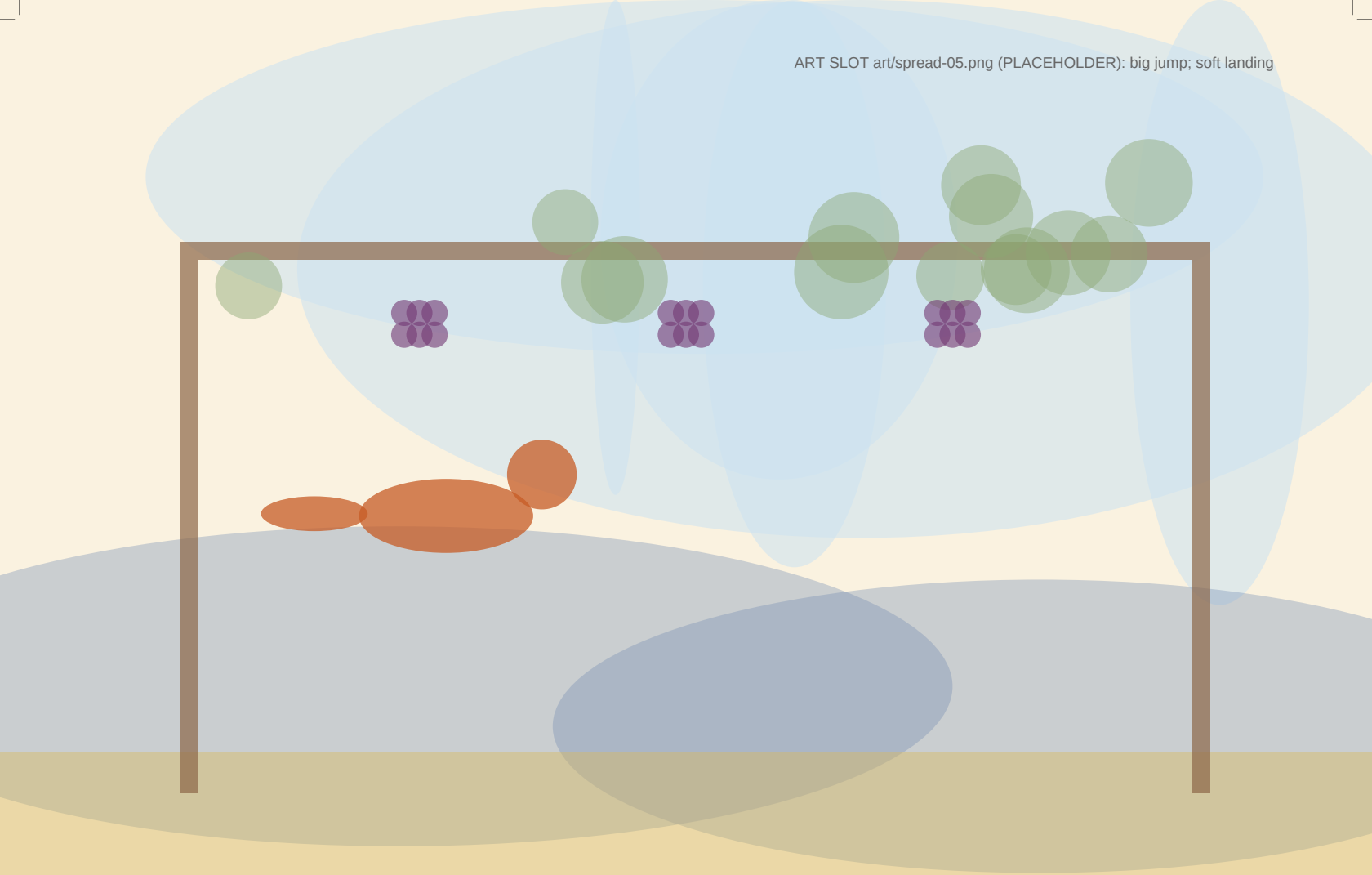
She tried from the left. She tried from the right.

ART SLOT art/spread-04.png (PLACEHOLDER): repeated attempts



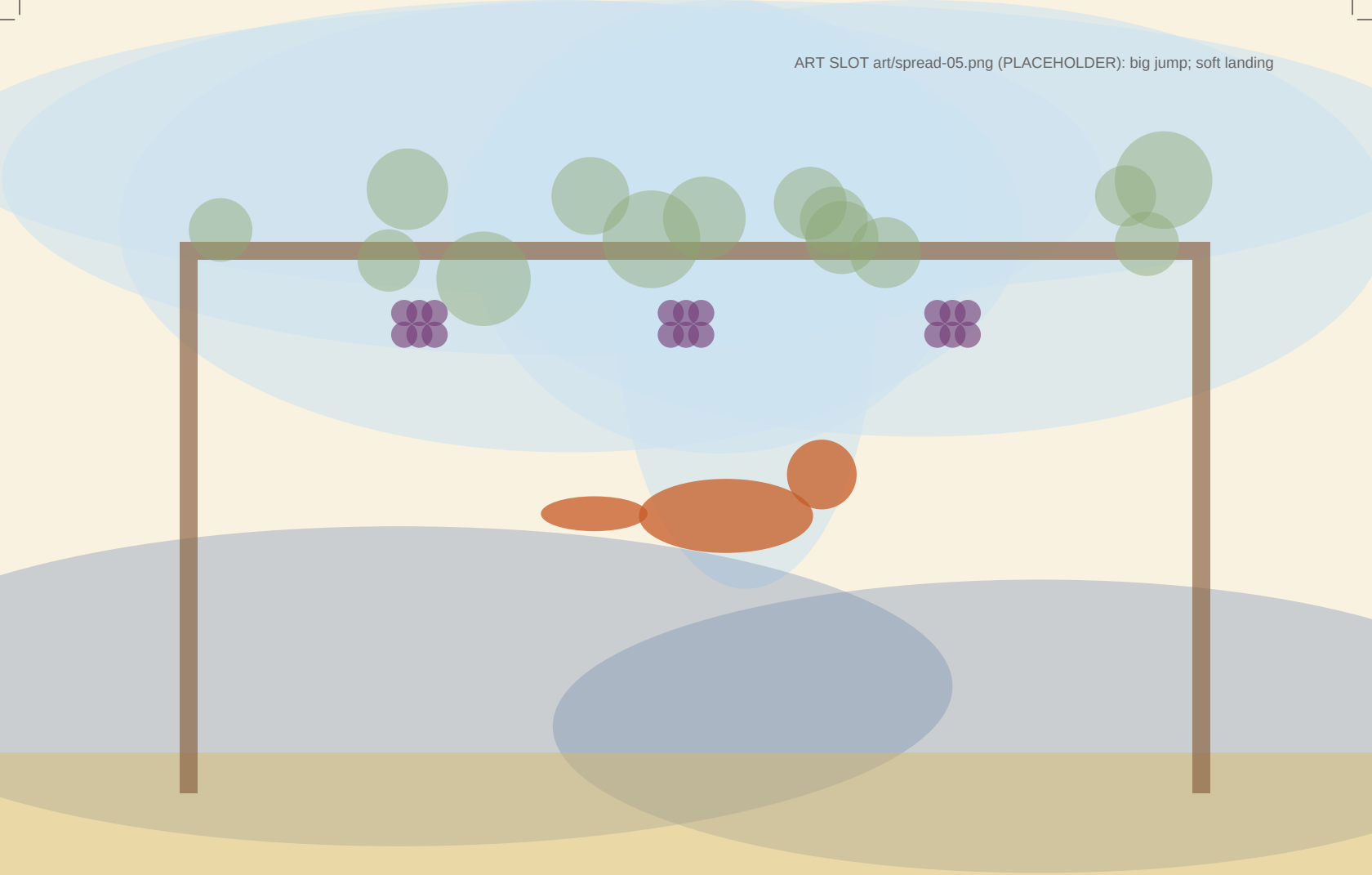
Up went her paws. Down came her paws. The grapes stayed high.

ART SLOT art/spread-05.png (PLACEHOLDER): big jump; soft landing



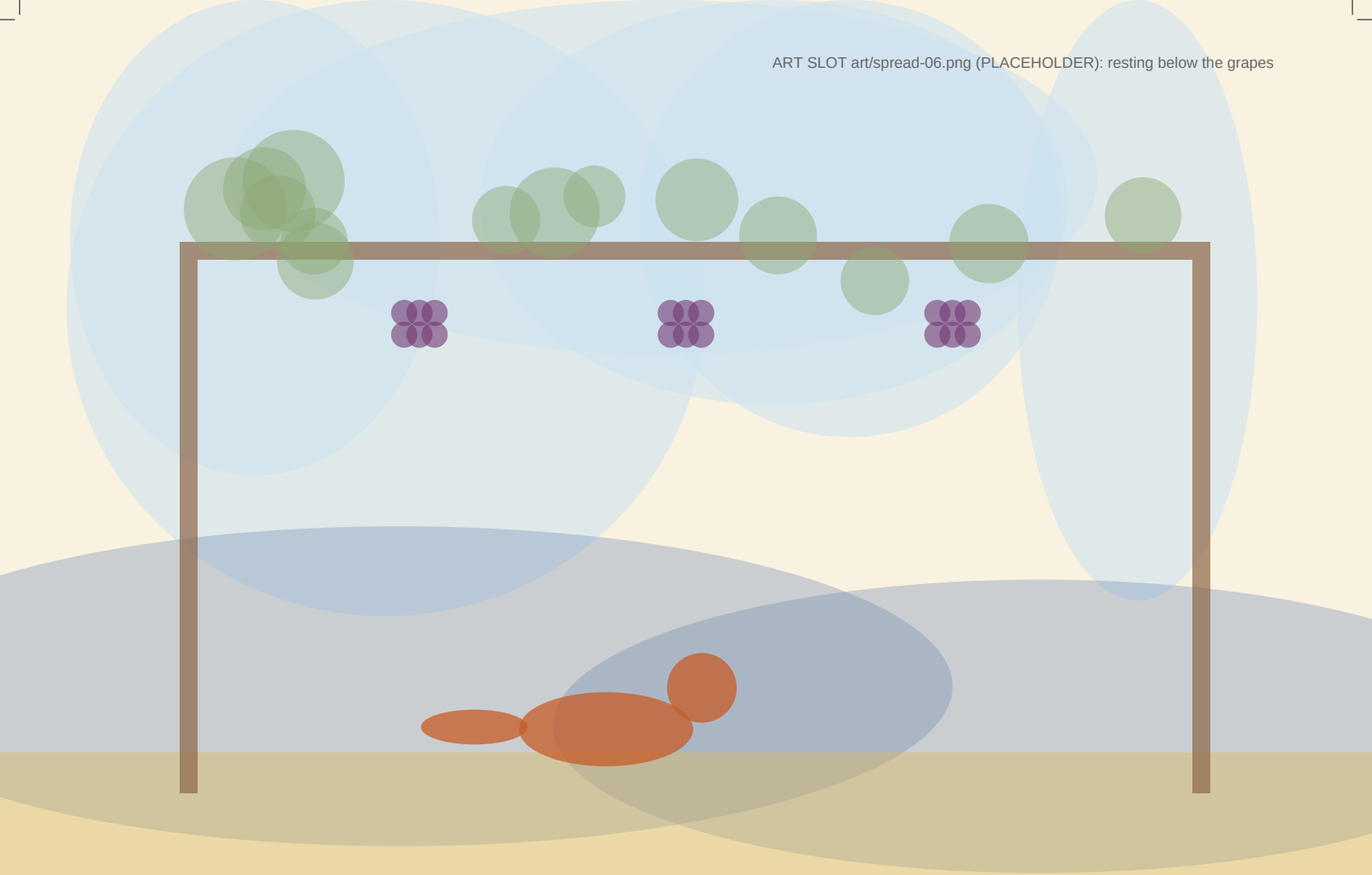
Fern backed up for one enormous jump.

ART SLOT art/spread-05.png (PLACEHOLDER): big jump; soft landing



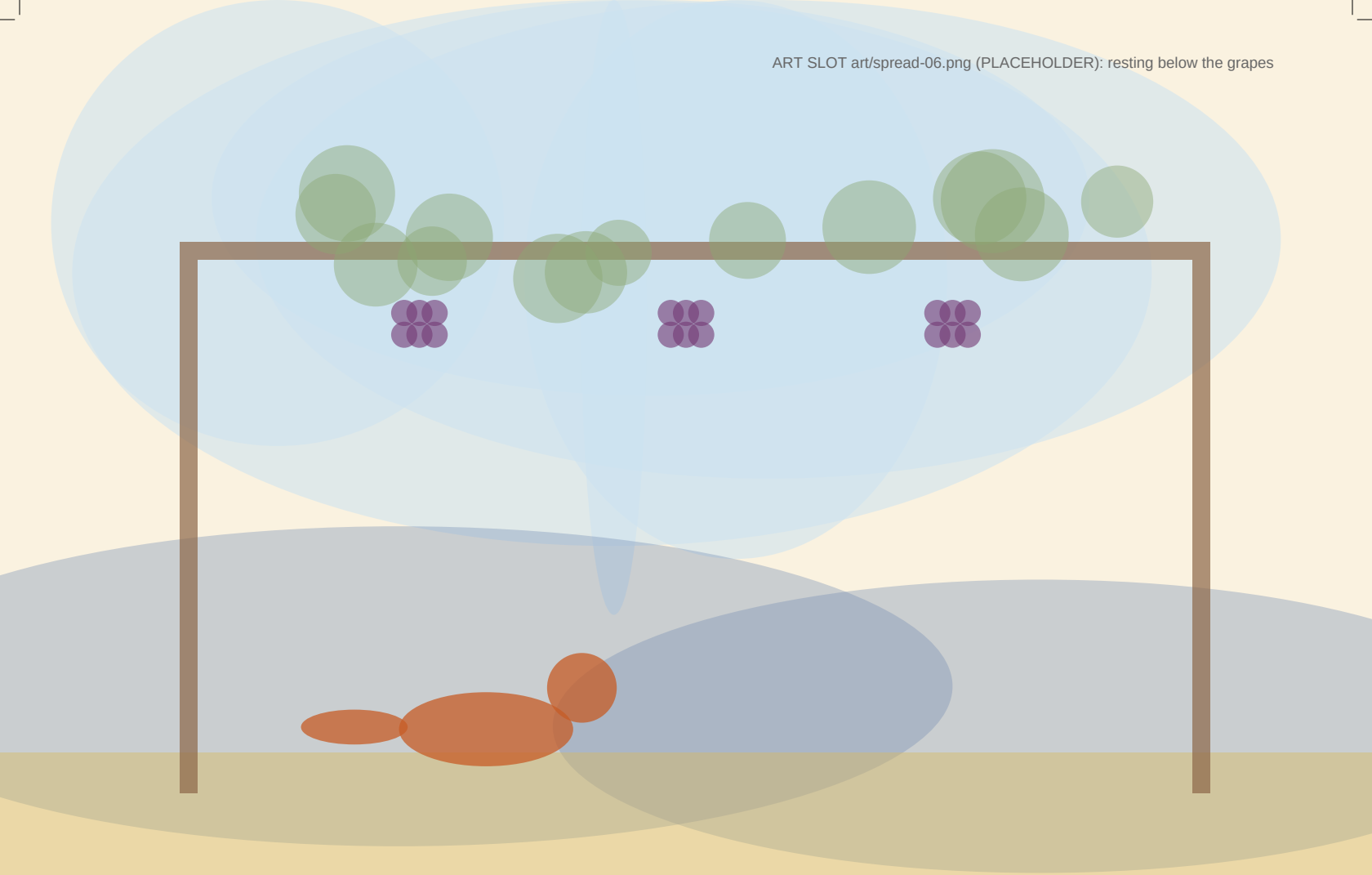
Whoosh! Her nose brushed a leaf. Plop! She landed in the grass.

ART SLOT art/spread-06.png (PLACEHOLDER): resting below the grapes



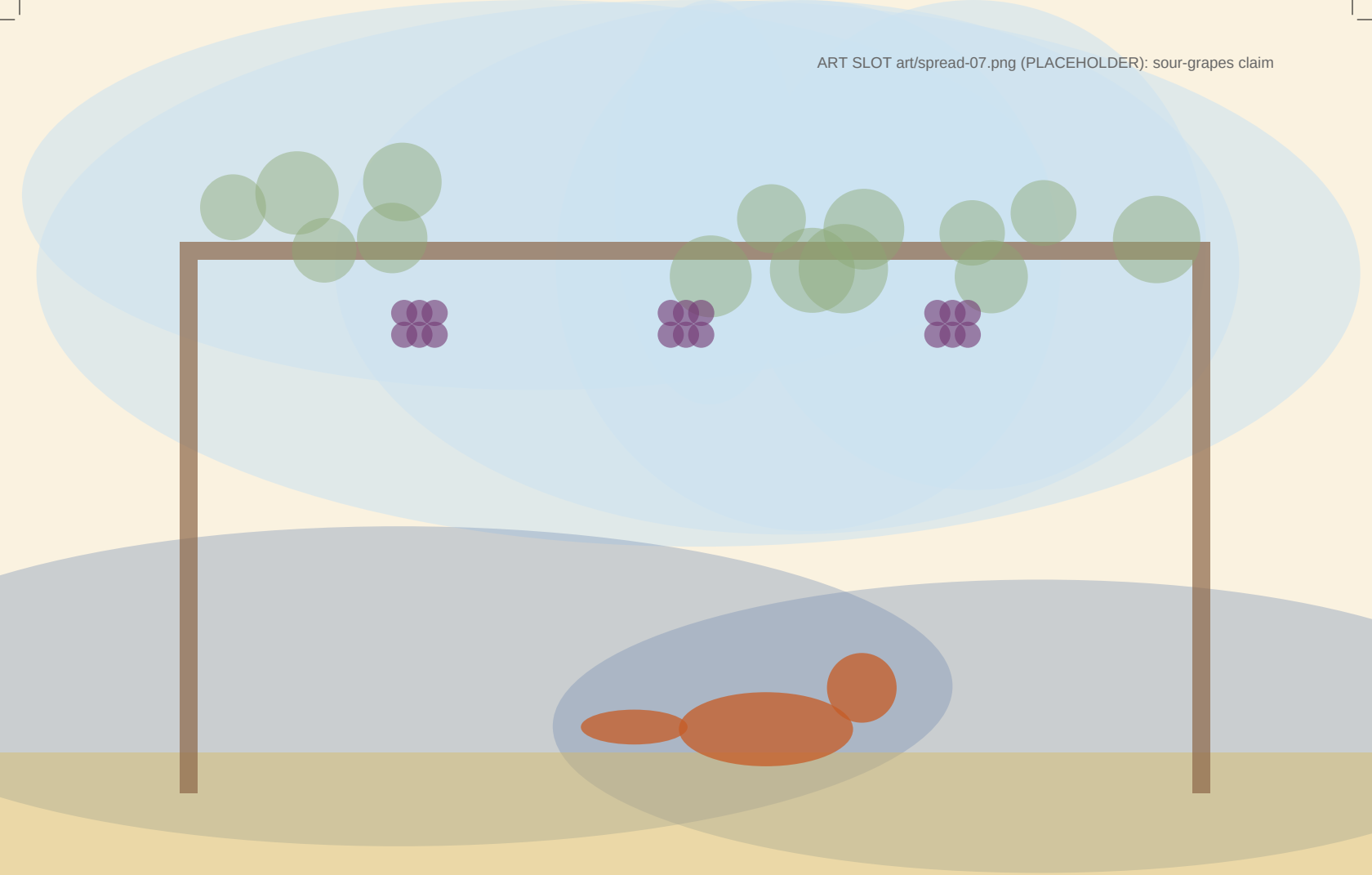
Fern sat down, puffing. She was tired, hungry, and disappointed.

ART SLOT art/spread-06.png (PLACEHOLDER): resting below the grapes



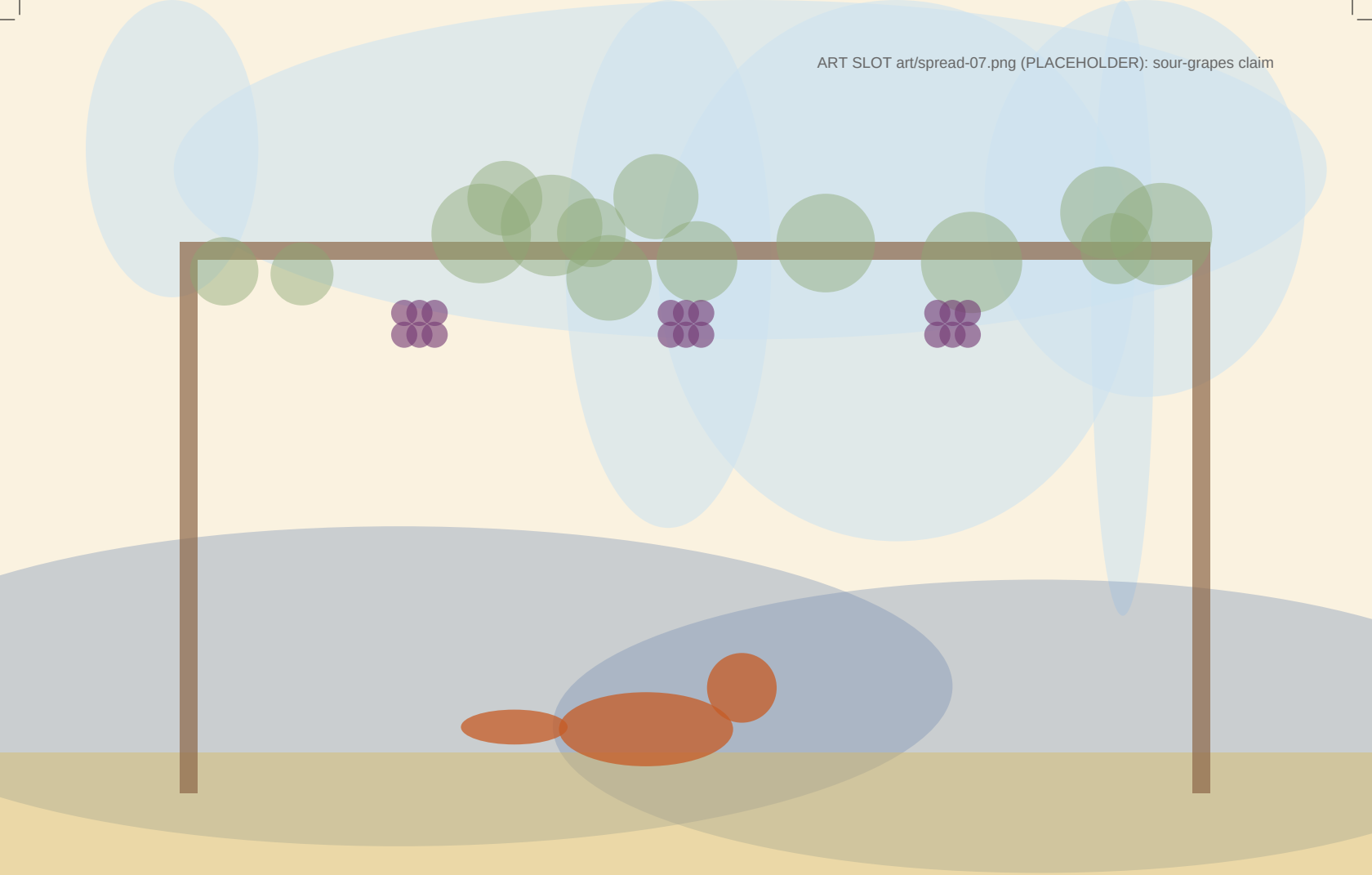
Above her, the grapes glowed purple in the sun.

ART SLOT art/spread-07.png (PLACEHOLDER): sour-grapes claim



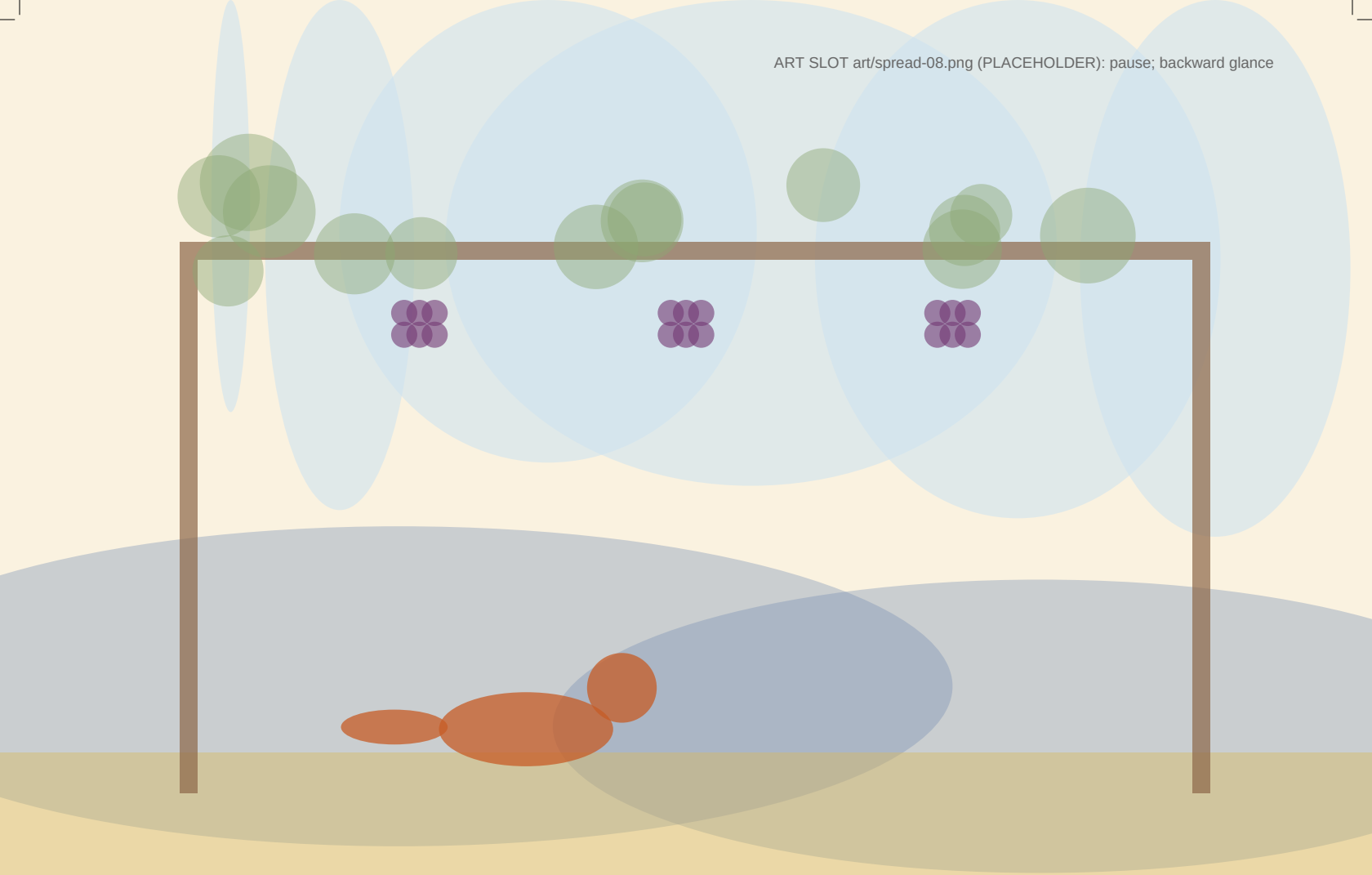
“They must be sour,” she grumbled. “I wouldn’t want them anyway.”

ART SLOT art/spread-07.png (PLACEHOLDER): sour-grapes claim



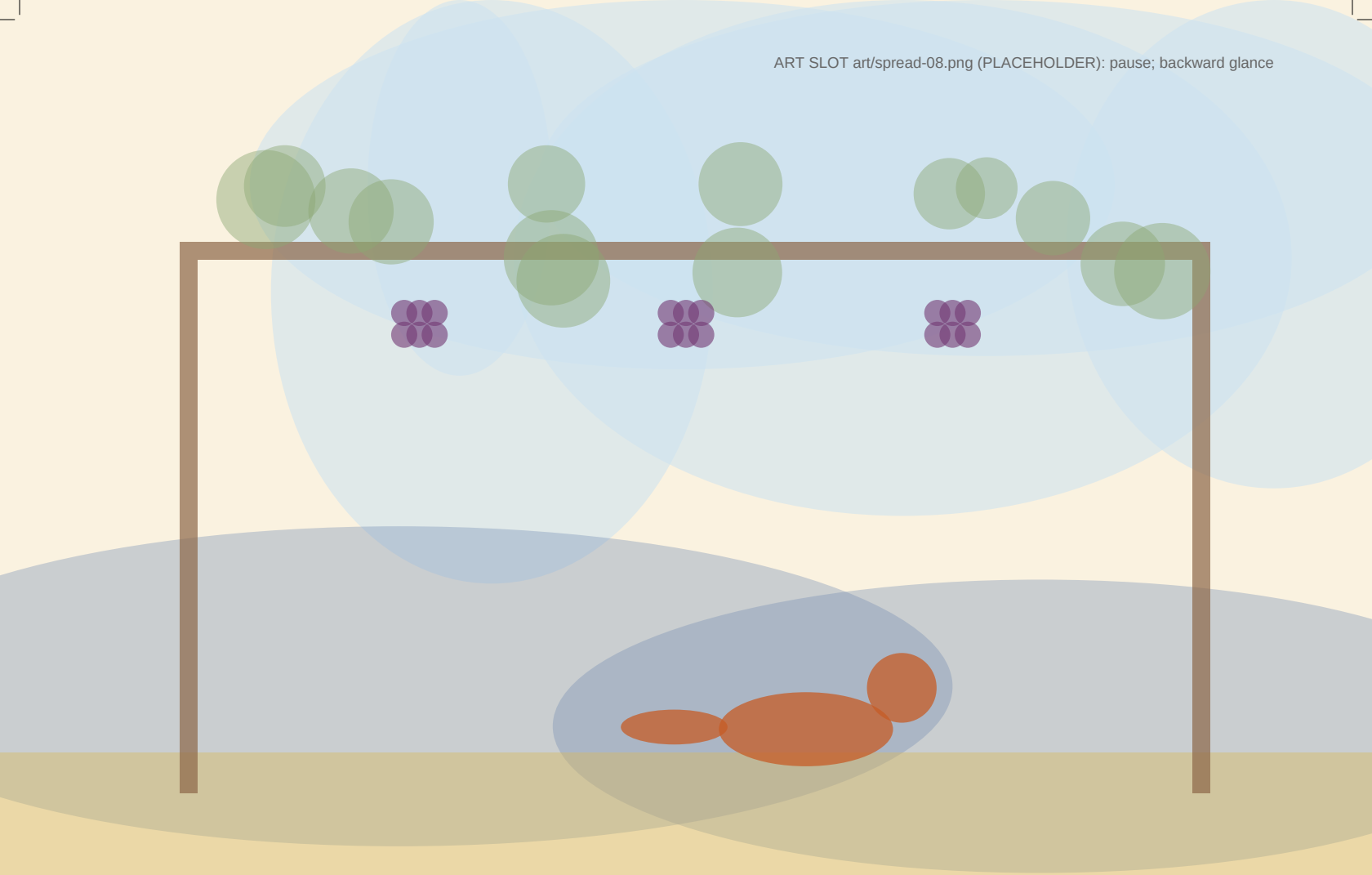
She turned away with her nose in the air.

ART SLOT art/spread-08.png (PLACEHOLDER): pause; backward glance



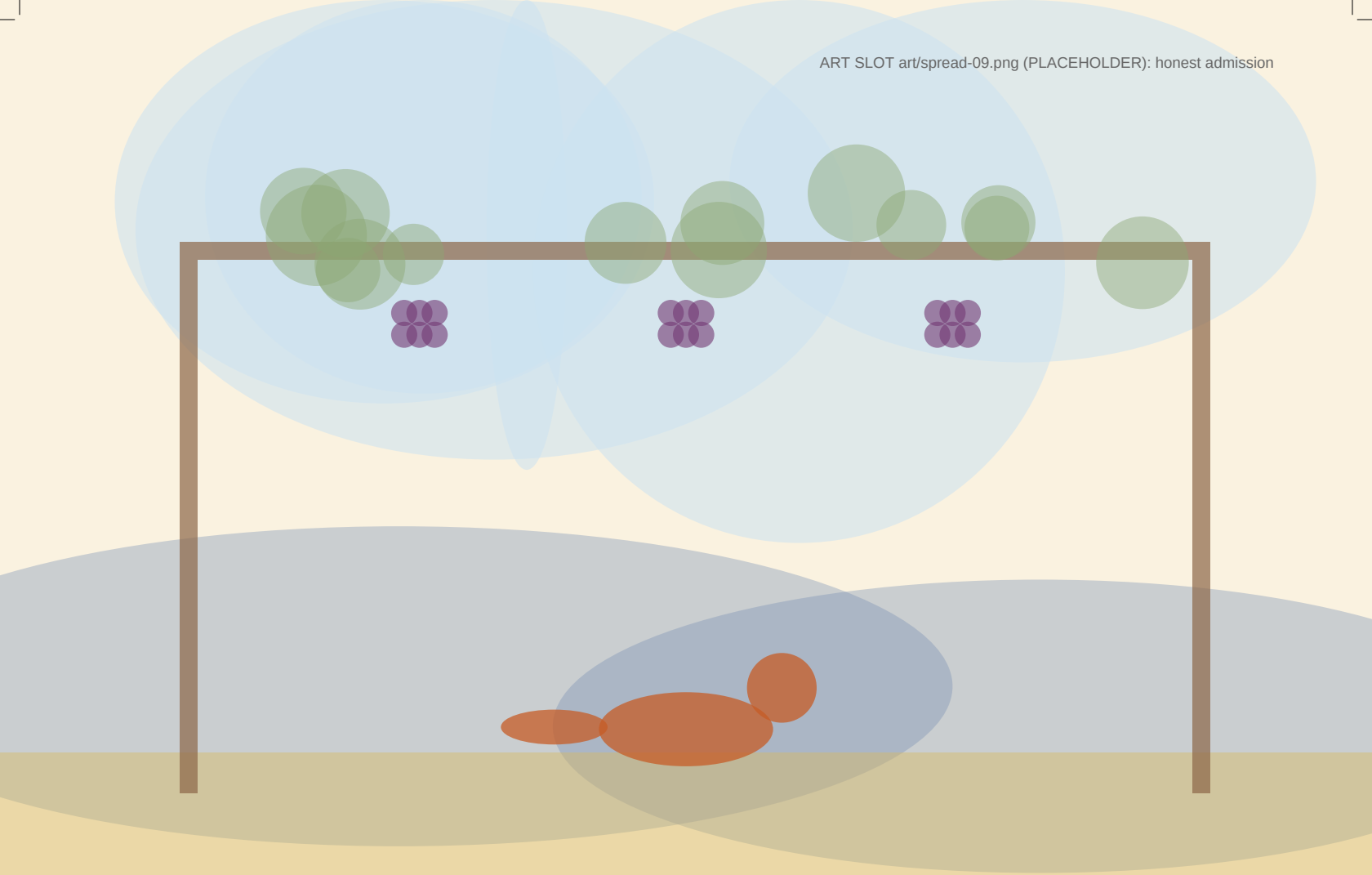
But after a few steps, Fern stopped.

ART SLOT art/spread-08.png (PLACEHOLDER): pause; backward glance



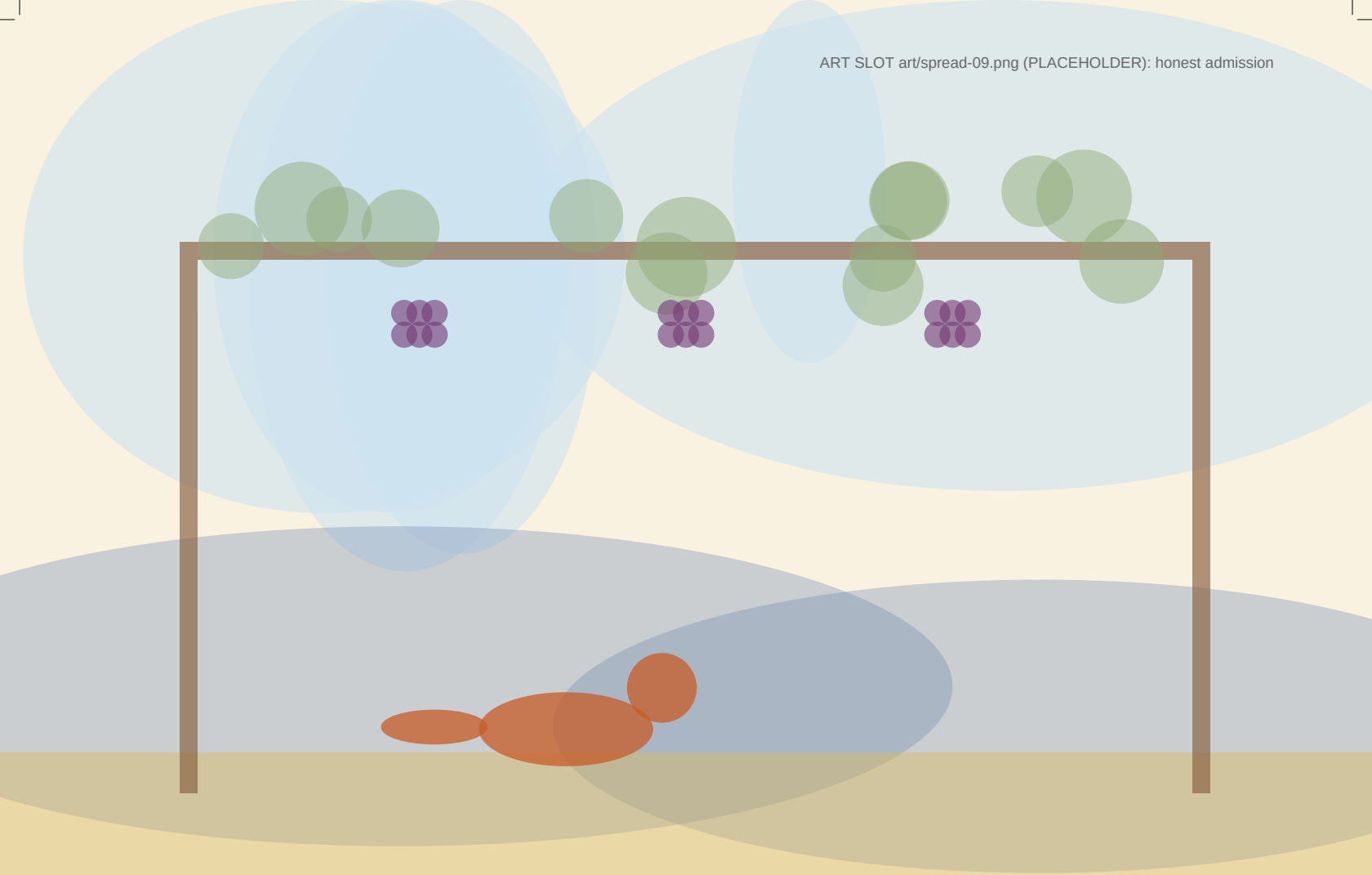
She had not tasted even one grape. How could she know?

ART SLOT art/spread-09.png (PLACEHOLDER): honest admission



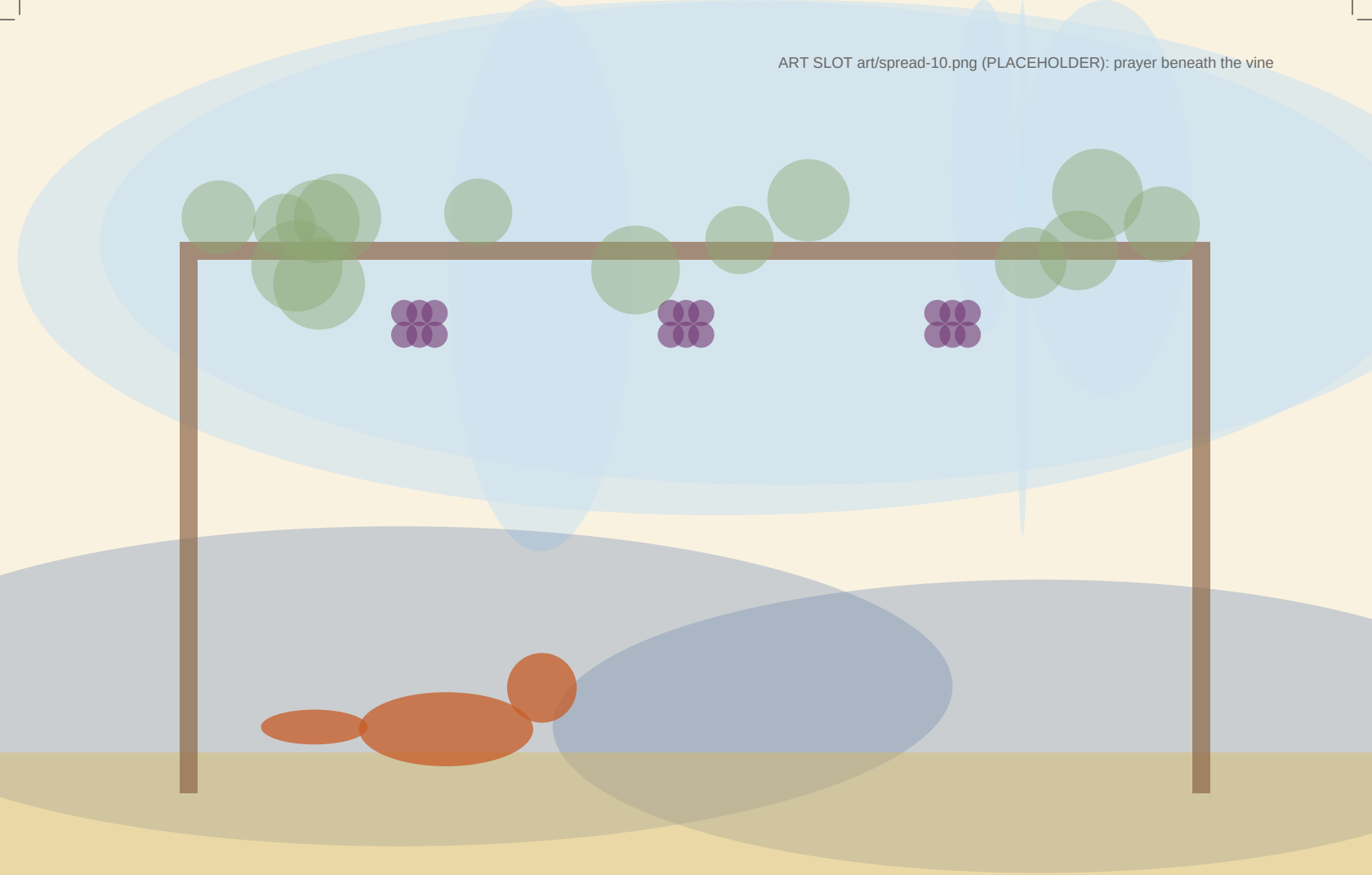
“I wanted them,” she admitted. “I’m upset because I can’t reach them.”

ART SLOT art/spread-09.png (PLACEHOLDER): honest admission



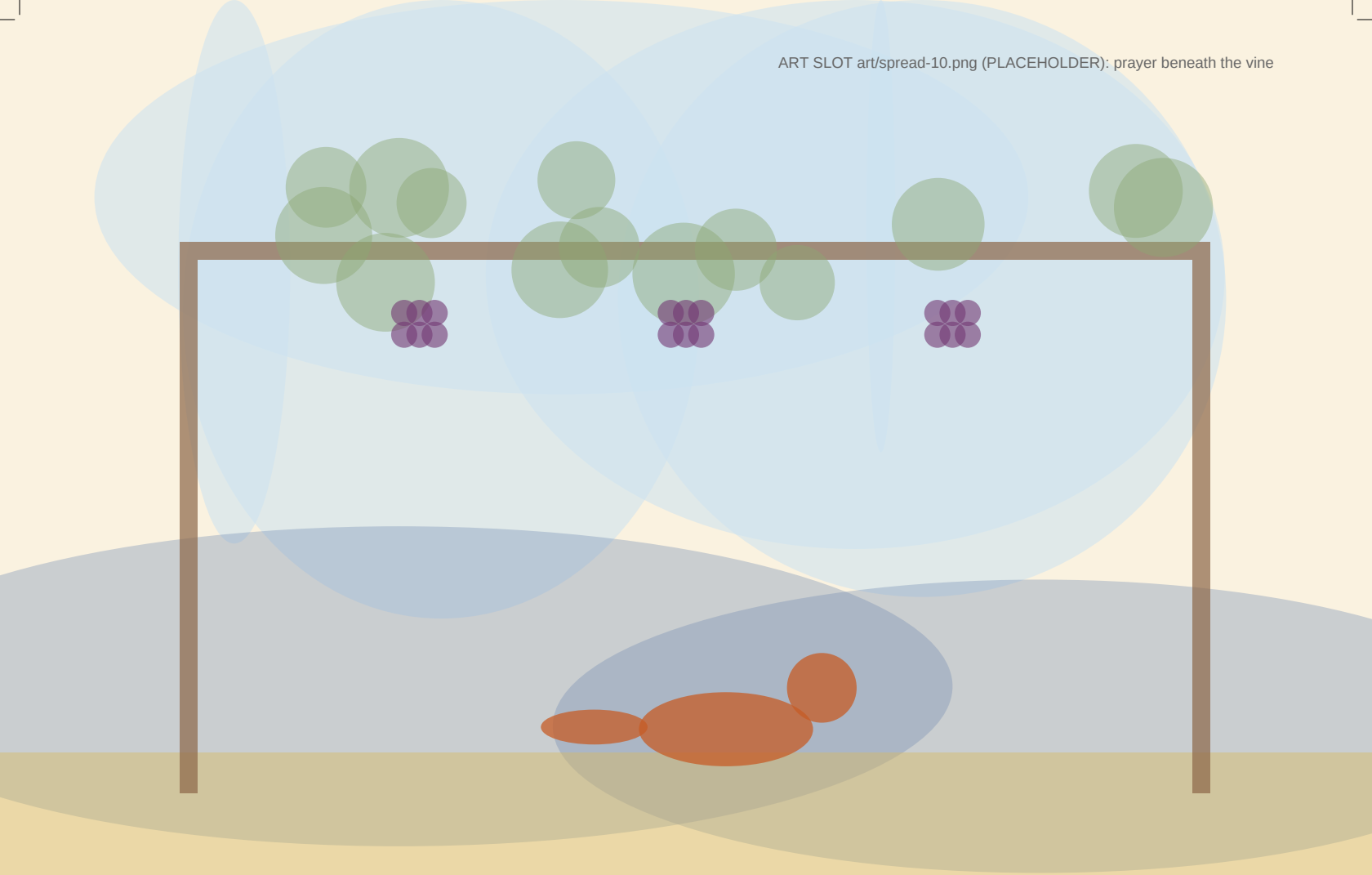
She let out a long, slow breath.

ART SLOT art/spread-10.png (PLACEHOLDER): prayer beneath the vine



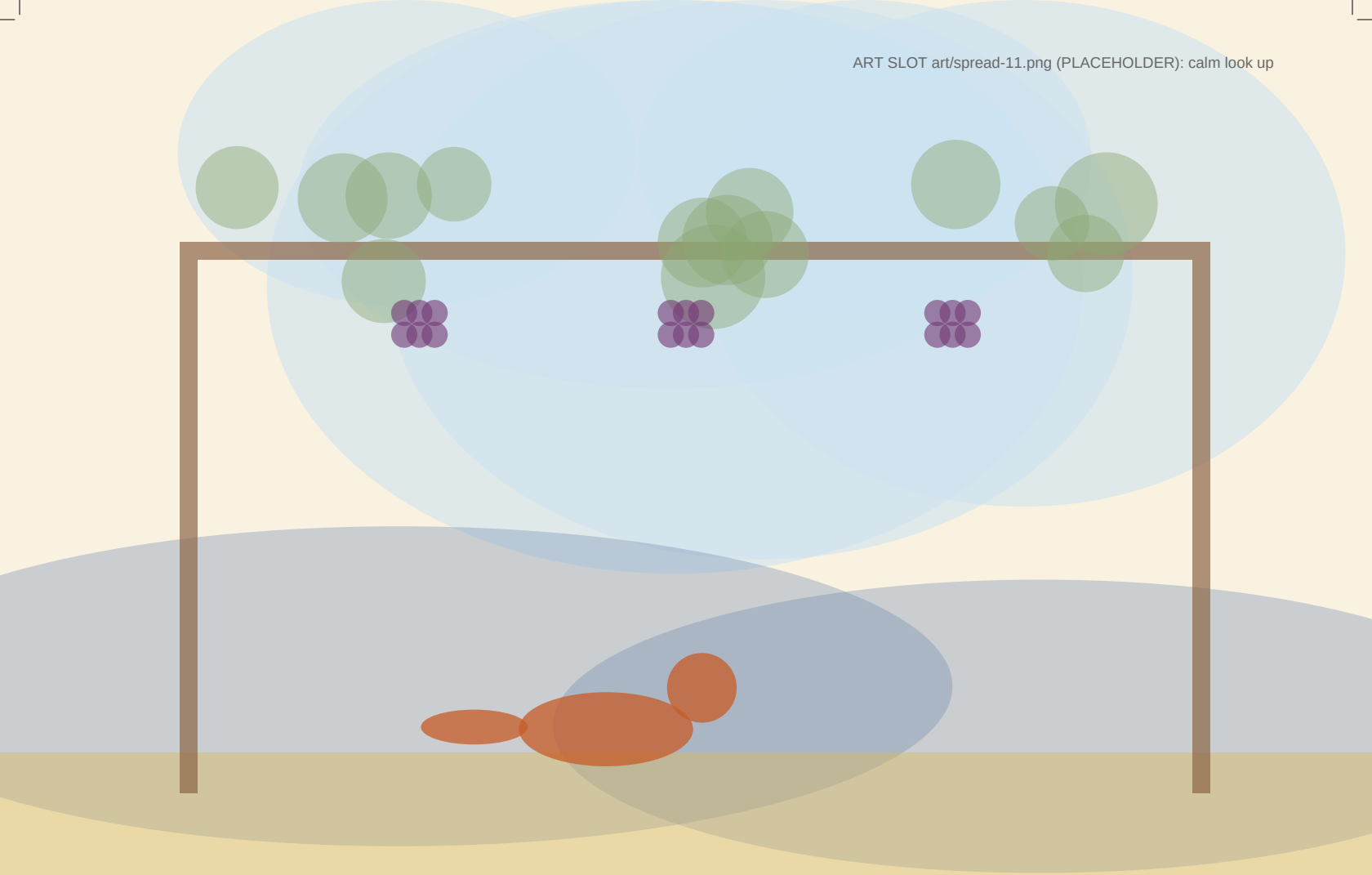
“God, please help me tell the truth and be thankful.”

ART SLOT art/spread-10.png (PLACEHOLDER): prayer beneath the vine



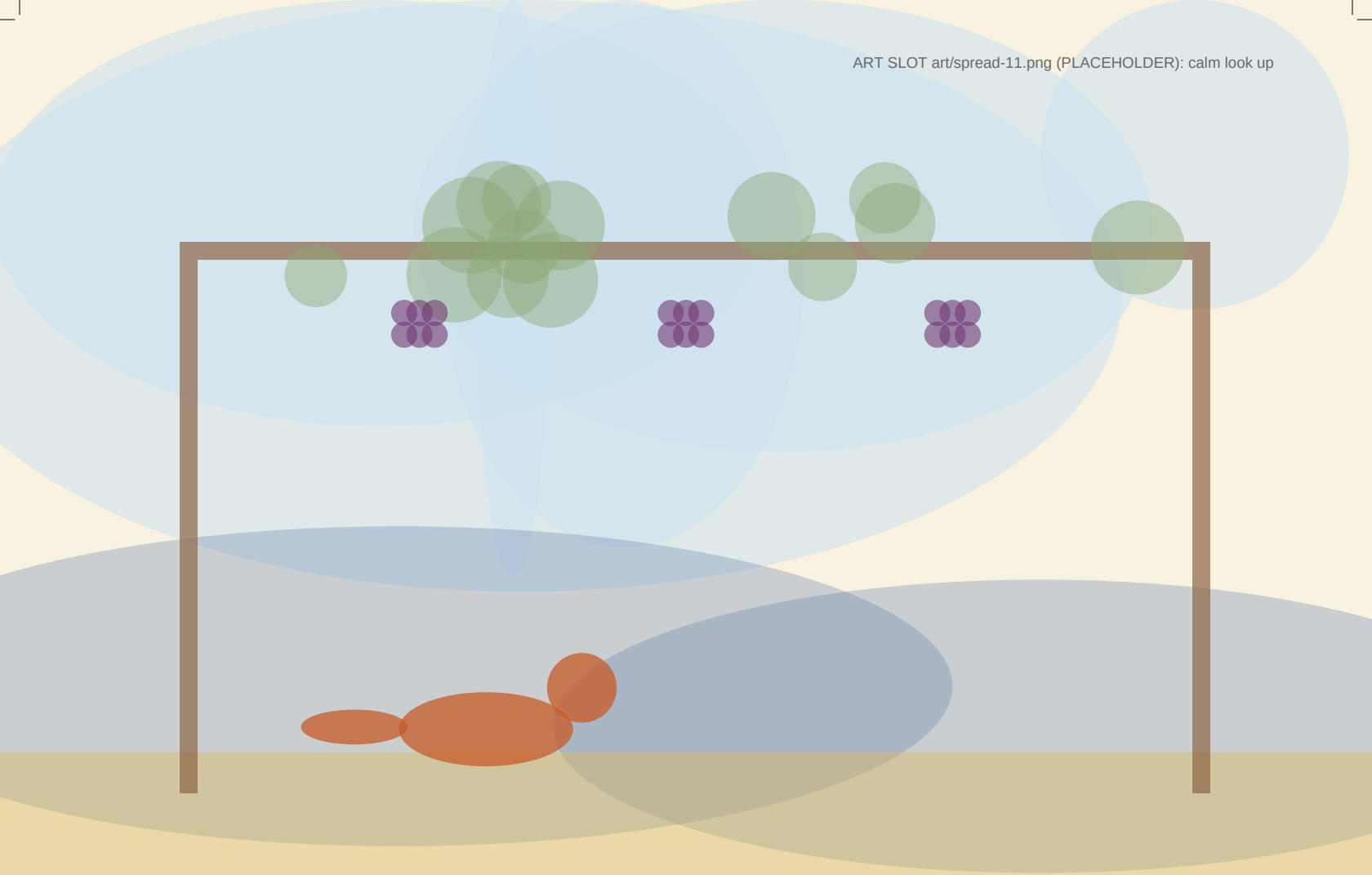
The grapes still hung high. Fern’s tummy still rumbled.

ART SLOT art/spread-11.png (PLACEHOLDER): calm look up



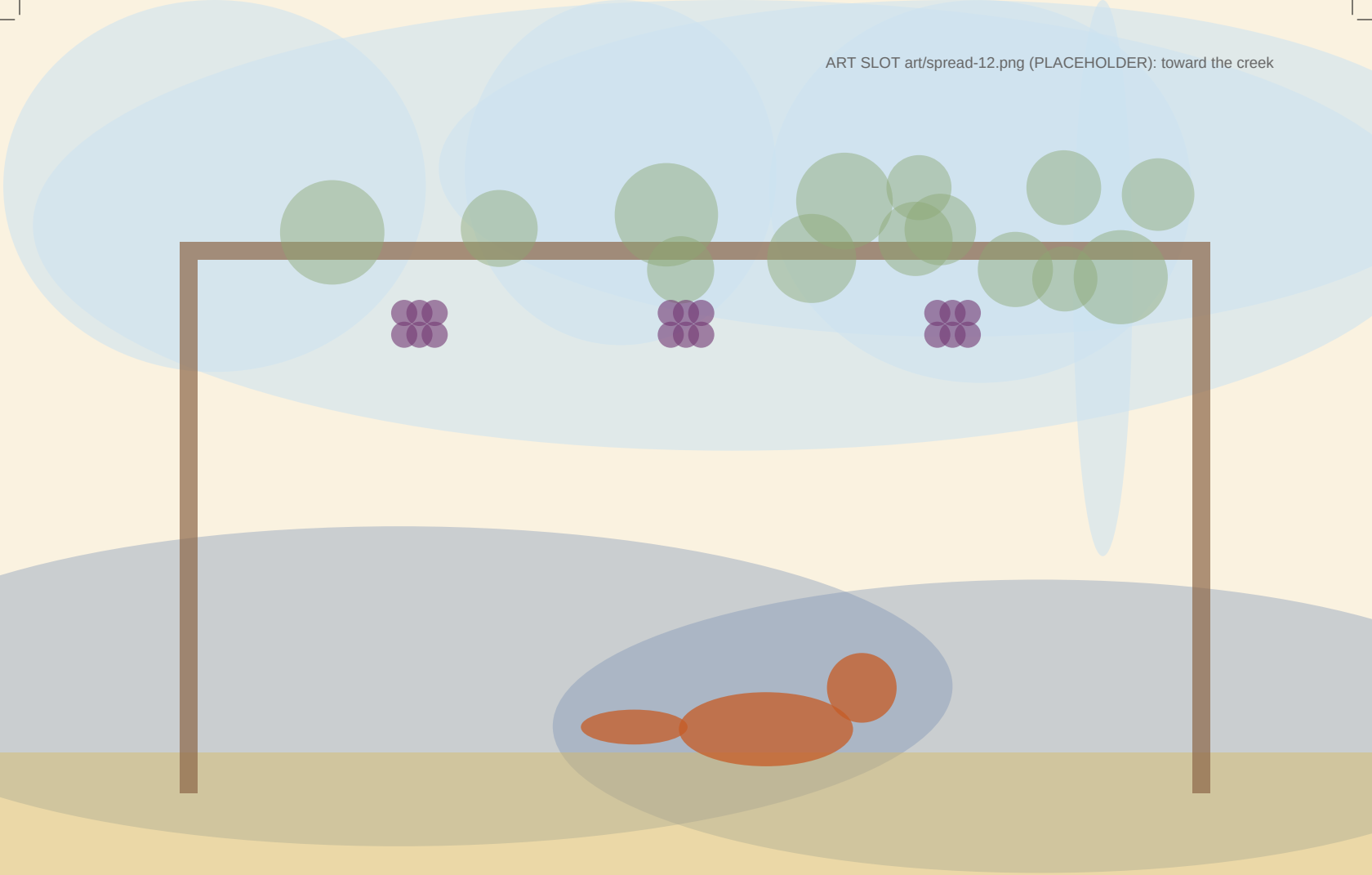
She could be disappointed without saying something unkind.

ART SLOT art/spread-11.png (PLACEHOLDER): calm look up



“You may be perfectly good grapes,” she said.

ART SLOT art/spread-12.png (PLACEHOLDER): toward the creek



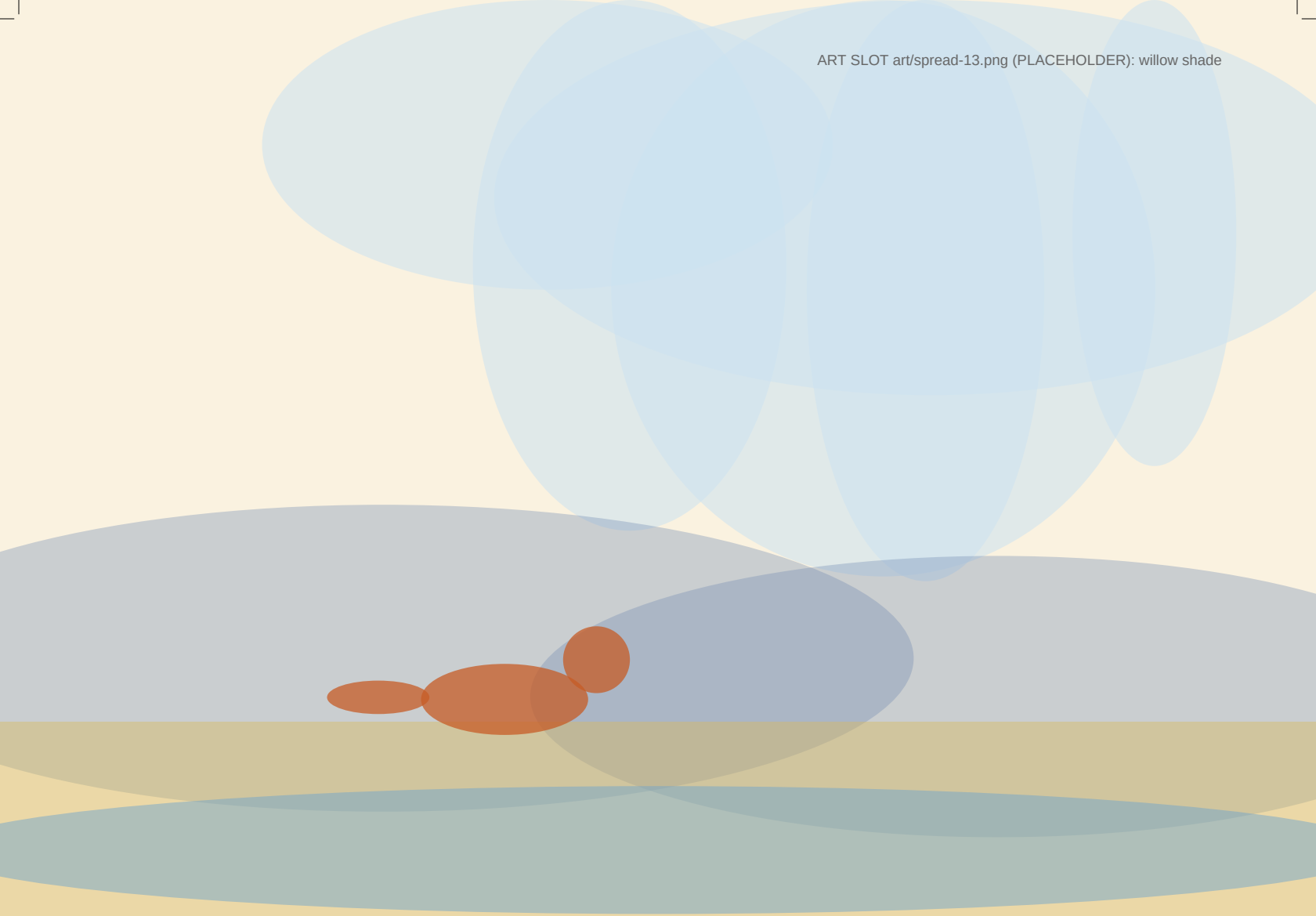
“I just can’t reach you today.”

ART SLOT art/spread-12.png (PLACEHOLDER): toward the creek

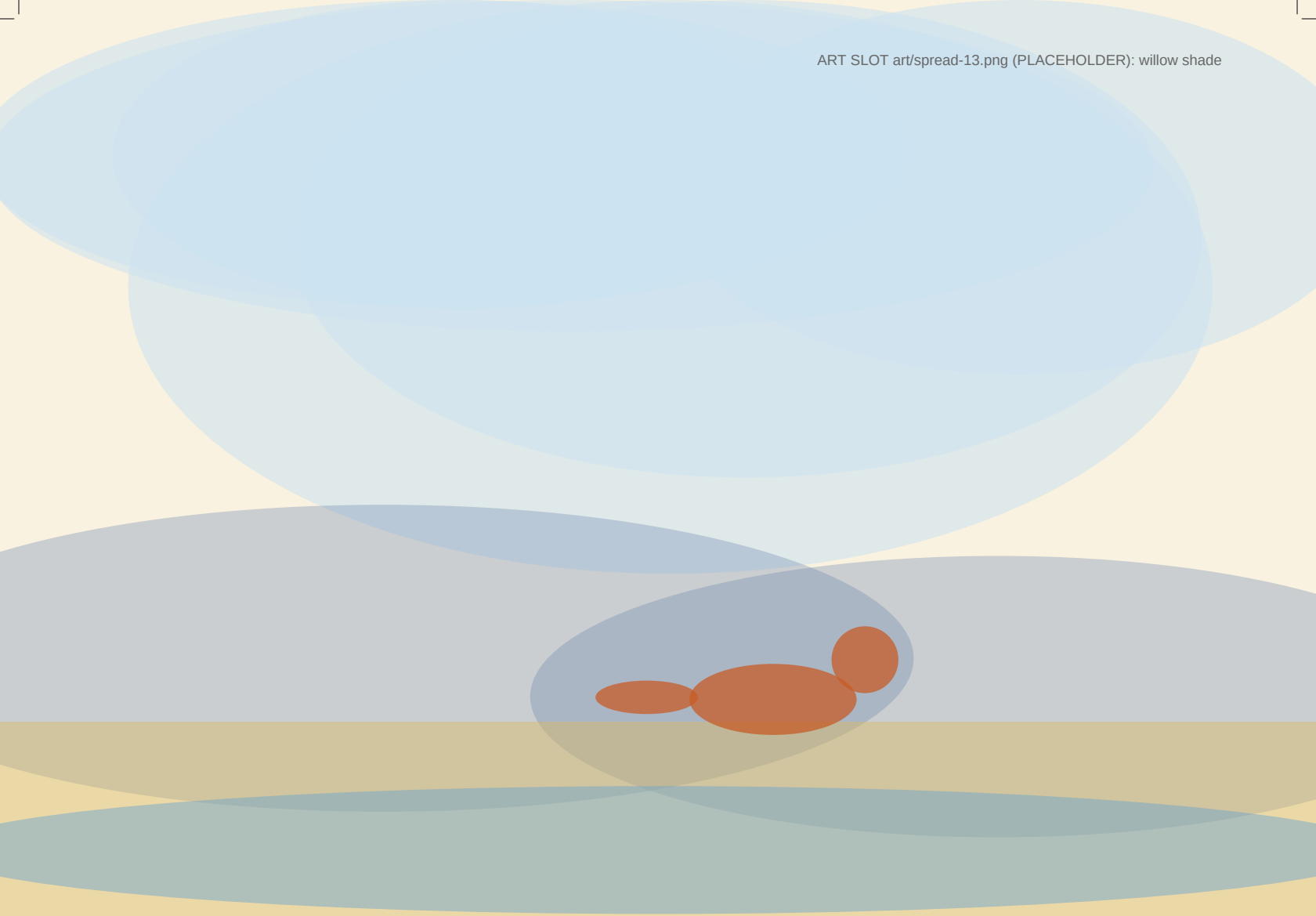


Fern padded to the shady creek and took a cool drink.

ART SLOT art/spread-13.png (PLACEHOLDER): willow shade

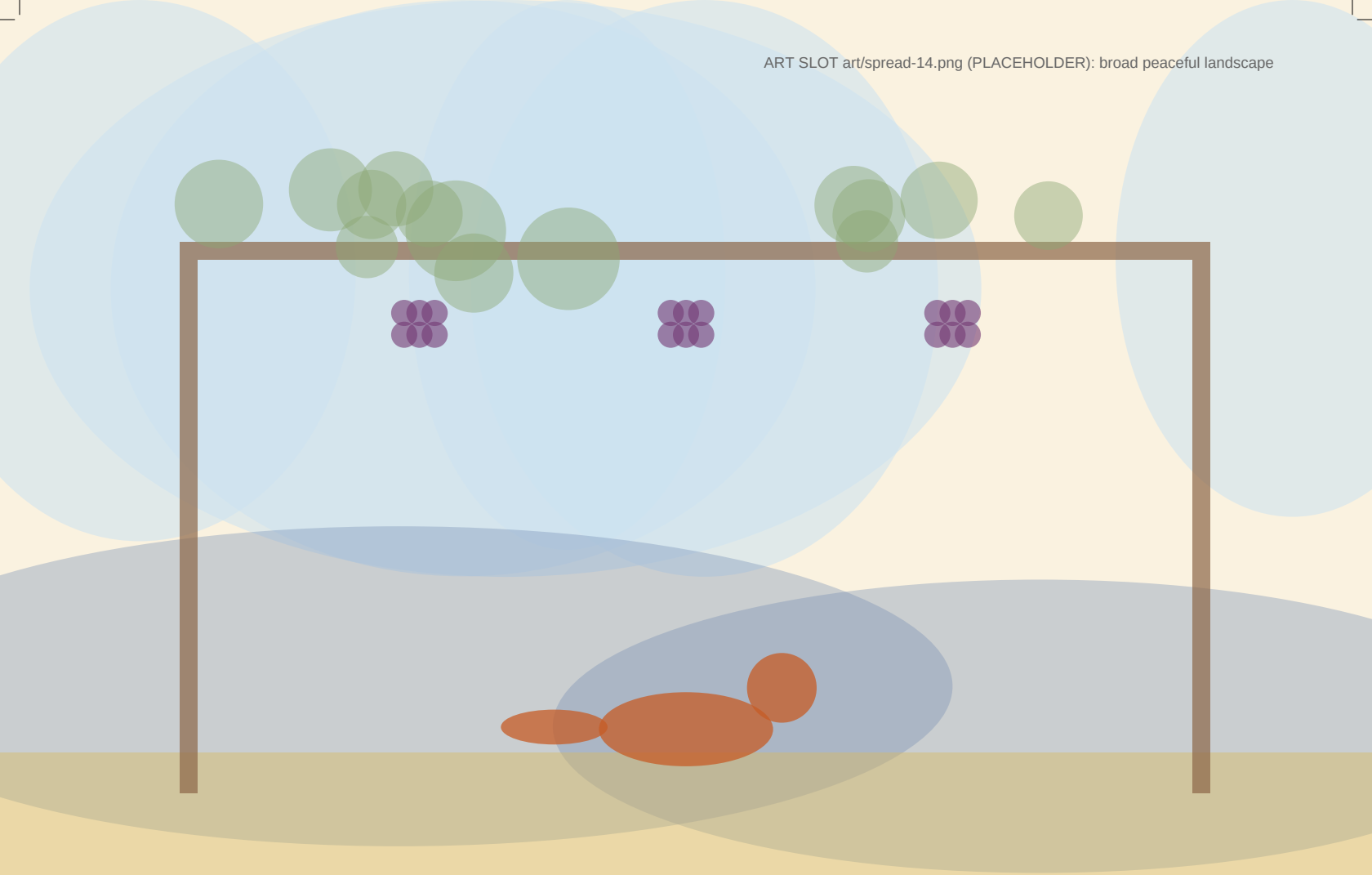


Then she rested her tired paws beneath a willow.



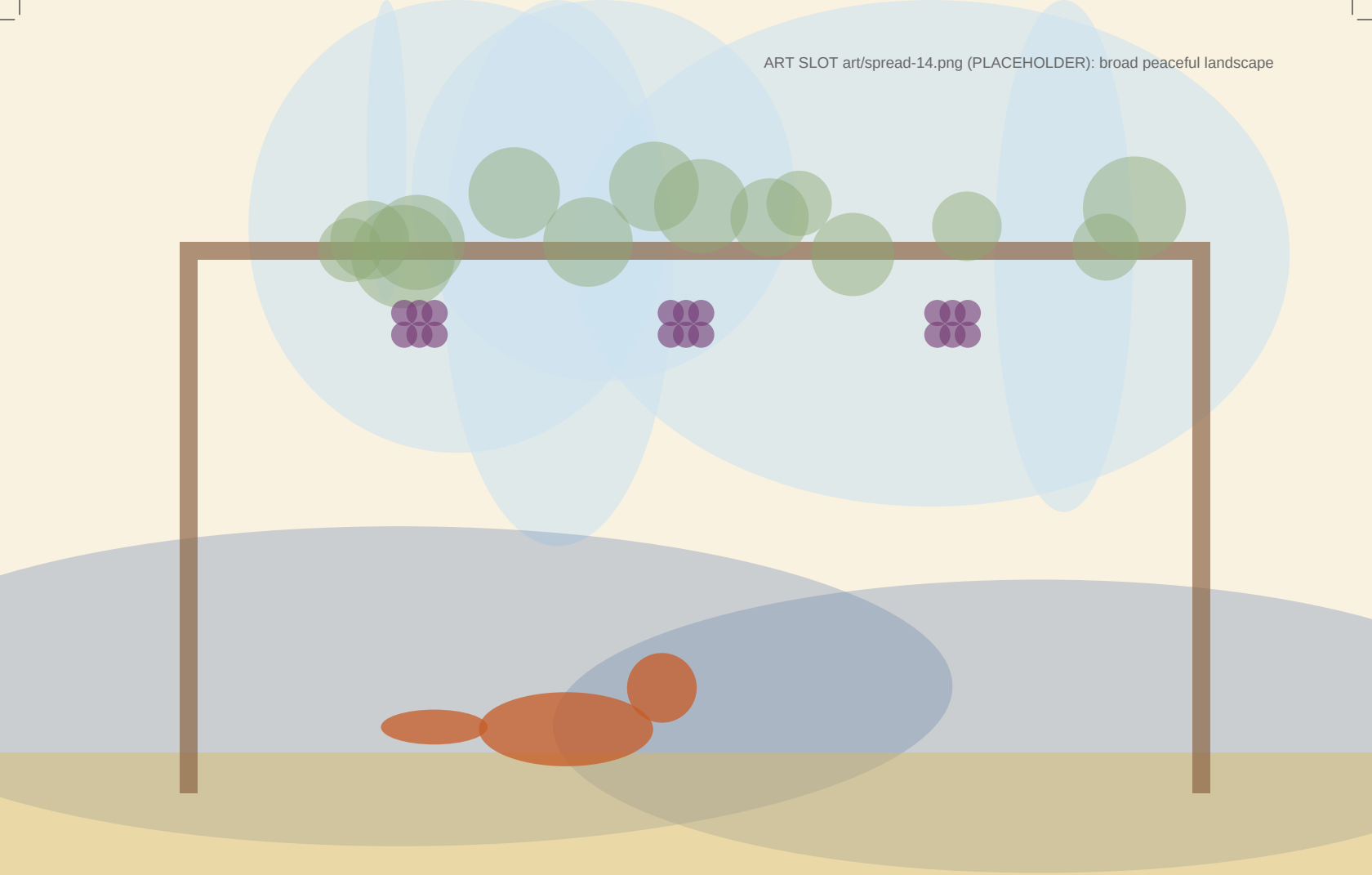
Soon she would look for supper. For now, she could leave the grapes in peace.

ART SLOT art/spread-14.png (PLACEHOLDER): broad peaceful landscape



When we cannot have something, calling it bad does not make us truthful.

ART SLOT art/spread-14.png (PLACEHOLDER): broad peaceful landscape



With God’s help, we can practice self-control and learn contentment.

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law.

Galatians 5:22-23 (BSB)



I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances. I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. In any and every situation I have learned the secret of being filled and being hungry, of having plenty and having need.

Philippians 4:11-12 (BSB)



Source: "The Fox and the Grapes," The Fables of Phaedrus, Book IV, translated by Henry T. Riley and Christopher Smart (Project Gutenberg eBook #25512), archived at github.com/martyschoff/fables. This story is a NEW adaptation for young readers, not the words of Phaedrus, Riley, or Smart. Fern's pause, honest admission, prayer, and reconsideration are new material added in this adaptation. Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB). The BSB has been dedicated to the public domain.

